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Everyday Emily

There were a few good reasons the showdown between Emily VanCamp and Ali Larter was so highly anticipated. First, they both were top notch fighters. Second, they'd met before, and the fights were highly competitive.

But if you ask me, the biggest reason is Emily... and the rags to rags to rags to riches story that's gotten her where she is.

The beginning of her career was abysmal, with Em dropping six of her first eleven fights. She was quickly dismissed as a non-starter. Sure, she could put up a fight, but there were no hopes of a title in her future. She was the prototypical journeywoman. Nothing more.

Then came the unbelievable, expectation-shattering rebound. One that saw her take twelve of her next thirteen - nearly all of them by knockout or TKO. Suddenly, she was all anyone could talk about. The league was young and the roster small. Winning with that kind of consistency had her rocketing up the rankings. From nothing to serious contender in a little over a year, and she had the title directly in her sights. It was full-speed ahead for the unstoppable Emily VanCamp.

And then it all just... went away.

There was no devastating loss or momentum-killing injury. The winning just stopped. Her next fourteen fights saw her win only seven. A dead even split. In perfect harmony with those original expectations. The excitement faded. The spotlight moved on, in search of the next great story. Emily's stable owner - who had pinned all his hopes on her when the going was good - was forced to rebuild. And he couldn't do it around Emily. He needed new talent, with untapped potential. Not a fighter who would forever be good, but never great.

But, then... what was the deal with that stretch in the middle?

That's what we at RSI aimed to find out. Because while Em's former stable had expectations to meet and a reputation to defend, we didn't have shit.

Well, that's not entirely true. We had our two pillars in Danni and Steph. We had something special brewing in the form of Julianne Hough. And we had just stolen Emma away from the rest of the league after her former stable suddenly shut down. So we had the faintest whiff of a buzz forming around us, but everyone knew we still had struggles ahead. And since struggling seemed to be Emily's specialty, she seemed like the perfect fit.

The experiment started off about as poorly as possible. Two hideous losses in the span of six months immediately had us asking ourselves tough questions.

This was a time before we'd recognized the talent-diagnosing skills Steph possessed, so it was just Danni and I making the decisions. And - to be honest - we were only just starting to figure out what the hell we

were doing. So, every move we made came out a little bit shaky, but we still felt we had this one right. Emily had talent. Even we could see that. Despite her struggles, she kept a positive attitude, and no one in the gym worked harder than she did. So, we decided to stick by her, and we tried to give her the things she needed to succeed - including bringing in Roselyn Sanchez to be her sparring partner.

Would it work? We didn't know, but we had made our call. Time would tell if Emily was going to sink or swim, but, whichever it was, she would do it here.

Seven months later, Em's leftover ranking points from that short-but-brilliant winning streak gave her just enough to qualify for the fall tournament. Her seed was terrible, and her chances were nil. But our expectations were also small. She had been in two previous tournaments, and never made it out of the opening round. All we wanted was for her to do better than that.

She ended up making the semi-final.

The result was not earth-shattering. It's fairly common for a couple of competitors to make a surprising run at these tournaments, and Em had already established she was just that kind of fighter. The type that can occasionally pull a rabbit or two out of her hat. But for us... we finally had something we could sink our teeth into. Em had beaten some quality fighters during the run, and she had put up a pretty good fight in the semi-final - against none other than Ali Larter. If nothing else, she had once again proven she could do this. It wasn't much, but it was something to build on.

Then the unthinkable happened. One of those quirky special events the league is so fond of brought Emily nose-to-nose with Irina Sheik. The woman who had been the class of the division for years.

This was exactly what we didn't need. Em finally shows some promise, and now she has to walk out there and get trashed by one of the league's premier fighters?

Only... that's not how it happened.

No, Em didn't go out there and destroy the long-standing champion. In fact, her performance left a lot to be desired. But she didn't get destroyed, either. She hung in there for all three rounds, and she had quite a few bright spots along the way. Most importantly, she didn't look lost. Maybe she wasn't ready for an opponent of Sheik's caliber, but she was competitive. She looked like she belonged.

So, back to the gym for more hard work and training. Danni started to give her a little more attention, in the hopes we could get her on the winning track.

And whaddya know? It started to work.

One, two, three wins in a row. Then another face off with Larter. A long, drawn-out battle that went to the cards and ended up being victory number four. She followed that with yet another pair of victories. There was no denying it: Emily VanCamp was on the comeback trail.

Then... well, son-of-a-bitch... it was Sheik again.

It wasn't supposed to happen that way. Though Em was definitely on the upswing, she still had climbing to do. Climbing that would force her to get better, and make her ready for the likes of Irina. But a weird rash of injuries had wiped out all four of the contenders ranked above her... which left Emily as the only option when it was time for Sheik to defend her belt.

Was it a golden opportunity or a death sentence? The best I could realistically hope for was that it would be neither. I went in to that night hoping Emily would do well, and come out in one piece.

Emily, though, had much bigger plans. She didn't want to put on a good show. She wanted to win. And so she fought and clawed and gave it everything she had... and in the end, she battled the long-standing champion to a draw.

It was a stunning result, to put it mildly. I also happen to think it was wrong.

I usually try to keep a low profile when it comes to the press, but I made sure to get my opinion on record after that fight... saying loudly and clearly I thought Emily had been the better fighter. There was no hype or hyperbole involved. I said it without reservation because it was an undeniable fact. Punches thrown, punches landed, time of control... the stats clearly showed Emily led in every measurable category. I admitted the fight was close, but I also said it was my belief that the judges had given Irina the benefit of the doubt because of her stature in the league. No sour grapes involved. I knew that sort of thing happened, and accepted the so-called *champion's advantage* as part of the deal. But I also wanted the world to hear what I thought of my fighter.

Emily and I have never spoken about what I said that night. I have no idea if it made a difference to her or not. I only know that she was more committed than ever when she got back to the gym. Again, we did everything we could to help her along, but it quickly became clear she was taking matters into her own hands.

Six months later - with injury troubles still keeping the other four fighters on the shelf - Emily got another crack at Sheik. Expectations were high, but the fight didn't live up to the hype. Em fought bravely and left it all in the cage, but she never really had Irina in any trouble. The champion was in control throughout, right up until the point when she knocked a tired and desperate Emily unconscious in round three.

The result was crushing to me. I mean, god damn it... was this girl EVER gonna catch a break? Emily had been tossed on the trash pile twice, only to blitz her way back both times. She had worked so hard and long to get here. She deserved her happy ending.

But that's not how it works. This was a sport where you only get what you earn, and Emily was the first to admit her performance that night was far below championship caliber.

"This was a tough one, no question," said a dejected VanCamp afterward. "After our last fight, I thought I really had a shot. But tonight, Irina proved that she's the best. Not me."

I didn't sleep well that night... or the night after... or the night after that. Those words haunted me. After working so hard and coming so close, it sounded to me like Emily was giving up. The thought made me sick to my stomach.

Then we got back to the gym, and she proved me dead wrong.

There was no defining moment of truth. In fact, there was no moment of any sort. Em showed up with a smile on her face and her bag slung over her shoulder. She got dressed and hit the heavy bag to get warmed up. Then she got started with her day. Conditioning drills. Strength training. She worked through her usual sparring with Roselyn and put a little time in with Danni, all with her typical level of intensity. There was no sign that she was quitting, or even any indication that the fight ever took place.

To me, the message seemed obvious. The goal was not achieved. There was still work to be done, and Em was fully prepared to do it.

That was the way it stayed as the months ticked by, with Emily methodically putting in the work - day in and day out. New challenges lurked around every corner as higher ranked fighters came back from injury. She focused on each opponent one by one, and took them out the same way. Never looking back, but never looking too far ahead. Systematically earning her way back to another shot at Sheik.

The process took over a year and a half, and I swear to god that every day was almost exactly the same. Maybe she'd try a new training technique or switch up the ones she already had, but the way she went about it never varied. Never got dejected after a tough day. Never got too full of herself after a big win. She just kept her head down and her nose to the grindstone. And when she finally earned that title shot... she was more than ready.

The fight was as much about sheer will as it was about talent and technique. The two warriors gave everything they had, unleashing blow after crushing blow. Within just a few seconds, it was clear that something big was going to have to happen. Someone's defense would slip, and the other would have to be quick and accurate in order to land the killer shot. And on that night, the shot came from VanCamp's right foot. The blow we at RSI will forever refer to as The High Kick From Hell.

Sheik hit the deck and the place went nuts. Emily stood frozen in her stance. Ever ready to deal with whatever her opponent threw at her next. Not comprehending that the goal she'd set out for so long ago had FINALLY been achieved.

Once reality crept in, a subtle smile appeared. A smile made up of pure, unfiltered happiness. The kind of smile that could not be removed. Seconds stormed in. Mini-celebrations were held. Danni got hold of the new champion and whispered something in her ear. Tears were shed. Through it all, that smile never left Emily's face.

Once her teammates got done with her, VanCamp made her requisite appearance at the post-event news conference. She still had her smile. She also had a shiny new belt up on the table in front of her.

It was the scene all of us at RSI had been waiting to see.

When asked how it felt to be the champion, Emily stated the obvious: it felt awesome. She talked about how hard the journey had been, and how proud she was to have earned her prize the way she had. Then she stopped and gently laid her hand atop the belt.

"This is special," she said to no one in particular.

The conversation went on that way for a while, until one of the reporters asked for Emily's thoughts on Irina's future. It was baiting, pure and simple. A chance for Emily to talk about how Irina was yesterday's news and how she was the champion now so you'd all better get used to it. Because that would make for a juicy story.

I'm sure that's what the reporter was hoping for, but it was no surprise to me that those hopes went unfulfilled.

"A lot of people are already talking about Irina in the past tense," Emily began. "I gotta be honest... it's the most ridiculous thing I've ever heard. She may be the greatest champion the league has ever seen. She's not going anywhere."

As if that weren't enough, Emily brought the fans into it.

"I love my fans, but I think part of the reason I have them is that they see me as a legend killer," she continued. "I don't know about that so much, but I'll say this: In order to be a 'legend killer,' you have to have a legend to kill. And Irina is, without a doubt, a legend."

Let us review, shall we?

This was a young woman who had spent years clawing her way to the top - repeatedly, mind you. A woman who had worked her ass off, beaten the best and silenced the doubters. A woman who had just won the title she had craved for so long. And she not only refused to crow about it, but she actually carved out a portion of her press conference to pay respect to the woman she'd just dethroned.

Trust me, it was no act. That's what you get with Emily.

You know what else you get? Consistency, dedication, level-headedness and just plain old intelligence. She proved it time and time again as she took the longest of long roads to the title, and she's kept on proving it, too. Her ongoing battles with Irina are one of the most exciting storylines the league has going... despite the fact that Emily has gained a stranglehold on that rivalry over the last handful of meetings. She has also taken on every last one of the elites in her weight class over the years, and proven her mettle against all of them. Through it all, she has only continued to improve... to the point that Irina Sheik is no longer the most feared lightweight in the league. Today, that distinction belongs to Emily VanCamp.

And if you want to talk to her about it, just stop on by the gym. You can find her at the heavy bag... or in the sparring cage... or helping the younger fighters polish up their game... or doing one of the countless other things she's been doing since day one. Because the titles and success haven't changed Em one bit.

In my write up after that first big win over Sheik, I latched on to Emily's own words and called her *The Legend Killer*. It stuck for quite a while - partly because it was fun and mostly because it was catchy. But I'm embarrassed to say it took me years to give her the nickname she truly deserved.

Everyday Emily.

Not because she's plain or boring, but because she's the most reliable person I've ever known. She will bring what she's got - and ALL of what she's got - every single solitary day.